

same way as a GIF. This is the most commonly used standard method for photographic images.

5.2.3 PNG

The PNG (pronounced “ping”) was developed to improve upon the limitations of the GIF, where machines capable of displaying millions of colours were outgrowing a format limited to just 256 colours. This is the chief reason why the PNG is growing in popularity among web designers who desire greater flexibility but maximum image quality retention. Most will resort to the PNG when a much more complex transparent image is required, perhaps one containing a very subtle gradient or shadow. The big problem is that there has been the lack of support from Internet Explorer up to version 6. IE will flatten your transparent PNG and render it as a block, revealing none of the colour underneath.

5.3 Prepare your template and style sheet

To illustrate the flexibility of background images, it is worth preparing a new template to experiment through the rest of this chapter. Create a new template called `images.html`, and add the following markup:

```
<html>
<head>
<title>Chapter 6</title>
<link rel='stylesheet' media="screen" type='text/css'
href='images.css' />
</head>
<body>
<div id="container">
</div>
</body>
</html>
```

Note that the body element contains just one child element, the container div we used earlier in the chapter. That div will act as the sandbox in which just one background image will be obeying your every command as it is shunted around, duplicated, and positioned. Note that a style sheet called `images.css` is linked from the head of the new template. Create that style sheet and paste the following into it:

```
/* Specify blanket rules for all elements */
```